everyone in a free-flowing conversation around the analytical issues and found it very endearing that some of the younger staff would challenge my views. In fact, this culture of speaking freely without any fear of consequences, rare in India's hierarchical traditions and even rarer in its bureaucracy, is one of the institutional strengths of the Reserve Bank, a legacy from which I benefitted immensely.

At the end of each strategy meeting, I used to take a poll of all the staff present, mostly mid-level professionals, on three options—cut the rate, pause or raise the rate. Although this was an oversimplification of the policy matrix, it used to give me a sense of 'the wisdom of crowds' within the Reserve Bank—a crowd that I deeply valued.

Technical Advisory Committee

Under the RBI Act, it is the governor who decides on monetary policy. As I write this, there is an initiative under way to introduce the system of a Monetary Policy Committee so as to make monetary policy-setting the collective decision of a committee rather than that of an individual. Even though there was no MPC during my time, the Reserve Bank has had, since 2005, a Technical Advisory Committee (TAC) to advise the governor on the policy stance. The committee is chaired by the governor and comprises all the four deputy governors and seven external members, all nominated by the governor. Two of the external members are drawn from the board of the Reserve Bank while the other five are chosen from a wider pool of economists from the academia and think tanks.

The meeting of the TAC is convened typically a week before the policy date. The TAC members receive, in confidence, a draft of the money macro document, which forms the basis for the discussion.

Chairing a meeting, big or small, formal or informal, is always a challenge. Through my long civil service career, I learnt that there is no one-size-fits-all strategy for an effective meeting. It depends on the subject matter, the format, nature of participants and the expected outcomes of the meeting. In some meetings, you have to loosen hold so as to allow a free